

# Safer sex

**Safer sex means having sex in ways that reduce the risk of sexually transmitted disease (STDs), as well as pregnancy. The term “safer sex” covers many different options, including using barrier contraception, choosing sexual partners carefully, and avoiding certain sexual practices.**

## What is safer sex?

Safer sex means having sex in ways that minimize the risk of catching sexually transmitted diseases (STDs). Because no method of protection is 100 percent safe, it is called “safer sex,” rather than “safe sex.” Although safer sex can also reduce the risk of pregnancy, it is primarily focused on limiting the spread of STDs for everybody. STDs are bacterial, parasitic, or viral infections that are passed on during sexual contact with a person who already has that infection. Many types of STDs do not have any visible symptoms.



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### GOOD TO KNOW

#### Effectiveness

No method of protection is guaranteed to be completely safe. However, they may help to reduce the risk of STDs. The only way to be certain not to get an STD or get pregnant is not to have sex, known as “abstinence.”

#### ◀ Being aware

As STDs often don't have symptoms, people that are sexually active should know the risks and take precautions to help them stay healthy.

## Unsafe sex

Unsafe sex is when partners do not adequately protect themselves against the risk of STDs. Sometimes this is intentional—for example, when a couple decides to have sex without using a condom—but at other times it can occur by accident—for instance, if a condom splits due to incorrect usage.

Regardless of the circumstances, acting quickly after unsafe sex is essential. The first step is to get checked out for STDs at a sexual health clinic, as treatment is more effective when it is received right away. As many STDs aren't immediately detectable, partners should be sure to use barrier contraceptives during sex until it is confirmed they do not have any type of infection.



### GOOD TO KNOW

#### Emergency contraception

If a couple hasn't practiced safer sex or their contraception fails, but they are keen to avoid pregnancy, they can obtain emergency contraception from a sexual health clinic or pharmacy. This is often known as the “morning-after pill.” Emergency contraception needs to be taken within 72–120 hours after unsafe sex in order to be effective.

#### ◀ Alleviating concerns

The possible consequences of unsafe sex can lead to stress and worry for both partners, so it's best to always take precautions and to be prepared to act if something goes wrong.